Ruinas Gloriosas y Directrices de Metáforas

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Editor of Genius

COL-311401

Editor of Genius

Corridor, H.A. Publishing House

A man hurries through a hallway, a folder tucked under his arm and two cups of coffee clutched in his hands. He turns the corner and collides head-on with a contributor.

A booklet falls to the ground.

Contributor: Please be a little more careful, sir.

Contributor: Hmm? It's you, Tommy! Here to beg Ms. Hunting to publish your ever-unnoticed expressionism literature again, are we?

Writer Thomas: Goodbye! I don't have time to argue with you today. I need to show this to Ms. Hunting.

Thomas picks up the fallen booklet and strides by without a second glance.

Editor's Office - Morning

The H.A. Publishing House, at the end of the third-floor corridor, in the office on the left.

Thomas, his movements brisk, takes two familiar turns before pushing open the glass door.

Writer Thomas: I'm sorry, Ms. Hunting. I know I'm a few minutes late, but at least the coffee hasn't gone cold. Anyway, before we discuss my publication, you simply have to take a look at this.

Movie posters are plastered on the walls between bookshelves, holding countless great literary works. The air is thick with the scent of coffee and ink.

Editor Hunting: No rush. Have a seat, Mr. Thomas. And thank you for the coffee.

Editor Hunting: Actually, you're already eight minutes late, but that doesn't matter.

Editor Hunting: I looked over your latest revisions. I think putting aside thirty minutes for this meeting was a little optimistic.

Writer Thomas: Which means ... it's good to go? Then, we can just—

Editor Hunting: First of all, Mr. Thomas, your work doesn't meet the publishing standards.

Editor Hunting: And second, you're refusing to cooperate with me. Not only have you kept some lines I marked for deletion, but you've snuck in a few extra sentences.

Editor Hunting: Now, let's use the remaining 20 minutes to discuss something unrelated to your manuscript. How about the recently released film The Atuel River Murder? I believe you could learn a great deal about storytelling from it.

Thomas concedes under the editor's relentless barrage, his enthusiasm doused as if by a bucket of cold water. Any argument he prepared is now left unsaid.

Writer Thomas: I see. Okay. You really are as strict as ever, Ms. Hunting.

Writer Thomas: But I can't give up on my work. It's the only way I'll break free from my mind. I have to find a way to get it published.

Editor Hunting: Then I wish you luck. By the way, the director of The Murder sent me a few tickets. I think you should take one and go see it.

Writer Thomas: I want you to take a look at this first.

The man gently places the booklet he's been holding under his arm on top of the movie ticket Hunting just placed on the desk.

Editor Hunting: And why should I look at it? I scheduled you last so I wouldn't run overtime, you know.

Writer Thomas: Listen. Guess who I came across on my way here?

Editor Hunting: What, you ran into your idol, Franz Kafka?

Thomas is well used to jabs such as these.

Writer Thomas: Here's the case: There's a messy-haired girl working at a café. Whenever she had a free moment, she'd pull out a thick stack of booklets and eagerly hand them out to any customer who seemed interested.

Writer Thomas: But the strange thing was there was no publisher, no category, no recommendations, not even a price printed on it.

Writer Thomas: I thought it was a hotel flyer, or a travel brochure, or a university club ad, or something, but to my surprise, it was a short story!

Editor Hunting: So, is it any good?

Writer Thomas: I think that it is more "special" than "good."

Writer Thomas: No matter what, please just read it. It won't take you ten minutes.

Writer Thomas: In less than ten thousand words, it manages to create something magical, something totally unique! It's like—like a literary demon leapt out of Pandora's box and tried to mimic human language for the first time.

Writer Thomas: The elusive metaphors, the layered structure ... Good grief! I can hardly believe it was written by someone so young.

Editor Hunting: Let me take a look.

For a time, there is no sound but the hum of the fan and the faint crackling of burning tobacco.

The minutes tick by, and a scratching pencil joins the chorus. At first gently and steadily, and then growing harder and more hasty. At some point, the lead snaps with a crisp crack.

Editor Hunting: Mr. Thomas, I have a request.

Editor Hunting: Can you tell this sleepwalking writer to meet me here before six? She's quite remarkable. This thing could turn the world upside down.

Writer Thomas: Haha! I told you so! I met her outside that café on the corner. If we're lucky, she should still be there.

Editor's Office - Afternoon

The young writer strides in, a box of the café's special honey-poached quince pie in her hands.

Recoleta: Ms. Hunting. How exhilarating that you asked for me by name! I knew that handing out my work for free would eventually pay off.

Hearing her own name, the editor looks up, surprised.

Editor Hunting: Oh? You know me?

Recoleta: We met in Guadalajara. I saw you at the booth of the H.A. Publishing House.

Recoleta: Later, a writer friend of mine told me that you're the golden signature of the H.A. Publishing House—especially skilled at helping authors rise to fame and even getting their works adapted to film.

Recoleta: If I'd known that back then, I'm sure we would've talked a little more, and I might even have a few novels published by now. Well, better late than never!

Editor Hunting: Hold on. When did I say I was going to help you publish a novel?

Recoleta: Huh? Isn't that why I'm here? After all, you said, "Let's bring in that little genius who could turn the world upside down!"

Editor Hunting: Did Thomas put it that way? Good grief. No wonder his writing is so flowery.

Recoleta: Then, why am I here, exactly?

Hunting walks to the window, pushes it open, and lights a cigarette. Recoleta notes how impeccably dressed she is.

The noise of the traffic outside makes her voice sound distant.

Editor Hunting: Give up writing.

Recoleta: I-I beg your pardon?

She can hardly believe her ears.

Editor Hunting: You're too obsessed with the purity of literature. Your work has no place in the '90s. It's all about films now. Listen, if I could send you back 30 years to a gun-riddled Latin America, I would. At least then you'd have a chance.

Hunting sends a puff of smoke out the window and taps her knuckles lightly on the desk. She fixes Recoleta with the gaze of a strict teacher.

Editor Hunting: Do you have a clear vision of your work? Any carefully structured or thoroughly polished ideas in your mind?

Recoleta: My vision is crystal clear! I want people to talk about visceral realism again, to capture the fleeting and make it eternal, just like the great writers of the '60s.

Hunting eyes Recoleta, a complex smile appearing at the corners of her mouth. She stubs out her cigarette and sits back down at her desk.

Editor Hunting: Let me rephrase that. You want to write good work that readers can understand, right?

Recoleta: That's right, Ms. Hunting. But I think it's difficult to balance that with literary depth.

Editor Hunting: No need to get ahead of yourself. Sit down. I've read your story.

Hunting hands over the open booklet. Recoleta's eyes are immediately drawn to the revisions covering its pages.

Editor Hunting: "Under their homeland sky, the shadows of the cowhands loomed larger than their bodies." This line isn't bad—quite vivid, actually.

Recoleta: Hmm? Oh, yes! And after that, the cowboy meets a cowhand without a shadow, not realizing that the cowhand's shadow is actually his own ...

Editor Hunting: "When the sun sets, their silhouettes stretch into great beasts along the mountain ridge, and they wave their whips to drive the nonexistent cattle." This part feels redundant.

Editor Hunting: Besides, how would the readers know that the cattle are a metaphor?

Recoleta: Okay. But planting a seed of doubt here allows for a wonderful moment of realization at the story's climax!

Editor Hunting: Now, look here, at this line—

Editor Hunting: "These cattle never lower their heads to graze. They'll chase the stars until they drag the cowhand's soul along with them. No one should dream of returning home. The land there will bite and bite at you until you can never leave."

Editor Hunting: Why did you write this?

Recoleta: It's ... it's a metaphor, too. Like the cattle herd.

Editor Hunting: I'm not questioning the sentence itself. It has style. But where's your theme?

Editor Hunting: This is clearly a story about the protagonist returning to their homeland after many years, exploring magical realism through the unfamiliar. So why, by page 5, am I still only seeing cowhands and cattle?

Recoleta: I understand what you're saying, but these are important elements of the novel. They'll all come into play later on. The cowhand looks exactly like the protagonist when he was a child. Actually, he's a phantom of the protagonist's childhood, but the protagonist doesn't recognize him.

Editor Hunting: Alright, I suppose there's some interest there. But how am I supposed to know that? Let's flip ahead to here—page 37.

Editor Hunting: Look, little genius. You took 37 whole pages just to tell the readers that the cowhand from page 5 is a mirrored symbol.

Recoleta: Ah, perhaps you're right. I really do need to adjust the structure.

Editor Hunting: Literature isn't the place to act out your private dreamscape. Do you think imagination alone will win over your readers?

Editor Hunting: Here's my suggestion. You're still young, and you have potential, so why don't you try studying screenwriting?

Recoleta looks utterly confused.

Recoleta: I don't understand. What does screenwriting have to do with literature? Every time I try to watch a film, I end up falling asleep before the end.

Editor Hunting: It's just a suggestion, though I understand, a rather extreme one. I just want you to stop underestimating the importance of storytelling.

Their conversation continues beyond the setting of the sun. Even so, the true marathon has only just begun.

Editor's Office - Night

By the time Recoleta lifts her dizzy head, the clock has already hit a quarter past eight.

Recoleta: Oh, it's so late! Sorry for taking up so much of your time, but what a thrilling literary discussion! Thank you!

Hunting rubs the corners of her eyes with her thumb and forefinger, leaning back into her chair, exhausted.

She has to admit her impression of Recoleta has changed.

Editor Hunting: Don't worry about it. It's been my pleasure to meet a writer as unconventional as you.

Editor Hunting: Phew. Alright, that's it for today. Go home and think over these three questions:

Editor Hunting: First, why does the cowboy return home? Second, why does he meet the bubble-blowing cowhand? Third, why do the characters know things that even the author doesn't?

Recoleta: Does that mean ...?

Recoleta's fatigue vanishes in an instant.

This is true, invaluable advice, not just the back and forth from a few friends. This is the guidance of a professional editor.

Recoleta: So, if I revise my novel according to your suggestions and come back, does that mean I have a chance at publication?

Editor Hunting: That depends on how well you revise it. I'm not making any guarantees.

Recoleta: I just need two weeks. No, one week. I'll bring you a completely reworked version.

Editor Hunting: If possible, I'd prefer you make an appointment at the front desk next time you come. At least let me know you'll be here.

She holds no high expectations for the young writer. After all, years of experience have taught her that writers have a tendency to exaggerate.

Editor Hunting: Best of luck. I'm heading home to warm up with a hot drink.

Recoleta: Till next time, Ms. Hunting. I'll most certainly be back; believe you me.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Cowboy and Coachman

COL-311402

Cowboy and Coachman

Editor's Office - Afternoon

The setting sun casts a deep orange glow in the office, causing Hunting to squint.

She sets down her pencil and leans back, exhausted.

Every name on the reservation list on the cluttered desk before her has been scratched out. All except one.

Editor Hunting: Phew. Alright, last appointment. Let's see. It's ...

Editor Hunting: "Recoleta"?

Recoleta: Yes! Is it my turn?

Recoleta: Long time no see, Ms. Hunting. Good afternoon.

The office door creaks open, revealing a fluttering feather and half of a pale face.

The editor gives a sharp inhale before nearly sliding off her chair in surprise.

Editor Hunting: You ... When did you get here?!

Editor Hunting: Never mind. That's not important. You're the last one today. Come in.

Recoleta closes the door and confidently places her manuscript on the desk.

Recoleta: Don't worry. This time, I've adjusted the pacing in the opening chapters. No more late exposition.

Editor Hunting: *sigh* If only I could believe you. Alright, let's get started.

Recoleta: Ahem—

An Andean valley breeze brushes over Hunting's weary eyelids as Recoleta begins her story.

Recoleta: *"The cowboy had never once considered going home. That was until he met the coachman. Like him, the coachman cast no shadow behind him."*

Recoleta: *"He boarded that battered carriage and embarked on a long journey, crossing mountains and rivers until finally, he arrived home."*

Recoleta: *"Yet, that long-overdue joy failed to reach him. He came to a stop. He surveyed that land, familiar yet strangely unfamiliar, and a chill crept up his spine."*

Hunting quickly realizes her eyelids have grown too heavy to lift.

The air thickens, distorting as her surroundings dissolve into shadows and vanish into fog.

Editor Hunting: Something's wrong. What's happening?

Editor Hunting: These images ... They're moving?

Distant mountains begin to form in Hunting's mind.

Editor Hunting: Wait, there's no need to give filming directions.

Templo de la Metáfora

When Hunting opens her eyes again, she and Recoleta are standing in a dense, foggy wilderness. The ground beneath them is dark and damp.

Editor Hunting: What ... What the hell place are we in?!

Recoleta: The fog is getting thicker. The camera pulls back. An ancient temple looms faintly in the distance.

Recoleta: Here we are—the "Hellplace."

Editor Hunting: Wait ... This is ... your story? I thought these scenes only existed in your mind!

Recoleta: Of course, they only exist in my mind. Everything is fiction. But this is the first time I've managed to bring a reader into this side of the world.

Recoleta: Increíble, Ms. Hunting! You truly are a great editor!

Editor Hunting: Huh? Why do you say that? Meaningless compliments don't exactly explain all this!

Emboldened by the spirit of adventure, Recoleta brushes off her editor's concerns.

Editor Hunting: Wait. But this is your story we're in, so we can leave whenever we want, can't we?

Recoleta: Oh, no, Ms. Hunting. This story isn't mine at all. It belongs to the cowboy and the coachman.

Editor Hunting: Then, where did they go?

Recoleta: Hmm. I think when we entered the story, we took their places.

Recoleta: Yes, we've become the cowboy and the coachman. Let's not waste any more time. Let the great adventure begin!

Recoleta's voice carries an odd, unquestionable pride.

Editor Hunting: Stop joking around, Recoleta. Can't we get out now?

Recoleta: Get out? Hahaha!

Recoleta laughs so hard that tears start to well in her eyes.

Recoleta: Our legendary adventure has only just begun. How could we cut the tale short? How could we let the readers know the ending so soon?

Recoleta: Of course, as the author, I can give you a hint. Inside this temple lies the "secret core" of the entire story!

Recoleta: Come on, Ms. Hunting, keep up.

Hunting wants to say something, but somehow she feels an irresistible urge to step forward.

Like a growing seed, a familiar yet long-forgotten sensation arises within her.

Editor Hunting: Wait. Don't run too fast.

She follows Recoleta into the mist. Soon, it becomes a fog so dense that it is difficult to see the path ahead.

Hunting grabs Recoleta's arm, forcing her to stop.

Editor Hunting: The scenery's been repeating. Haven't you noticed? We've passed this same pillar at least seven or eight times.

Editor Hunting: I can't see the way through all this fog. Let's just take a breath and take a minute to listen to our inner voices.

Editor Hunting: No, no, that's too abstract. Here, you need to keep the readers' attention. This giant pillar should be the story's MacGuffin.

Recoleta: Does that mean ...?

Editor Hunting: In short, we need to make this pillar a driving force. Let me think.

Editor Hunting: Yes, you need to rewrite this part: The cowboy and the coachman discover something unusual about the pillar in the repeating temple.

Editor Hunting: By touching its four sides in order, East, West, South, North, they finally escape the maze.

Recoleta: Ah, right, right. Let me see.

Recoleta: East ...

Recoleta: West ...

Recoleta: South ...

Recoleta: And North!

Editor's Office - Night

Recoleta: Ms. Hunting? Ms. Hunting!

Hunting jolts awake, a dull headache creeping across her forehead.

Was all that just a dream?

Editor Hunting: Did we come back?

Recoleta: We never went anywhere. Did you fall asleep?

Editor Hunting: No, forget it. Where were we in the story?

Recoleta: The cowboy and the coachman just escaped the maze. They're about to head toward the ending.

Editor Hunting: Alright, back to business. There are still quite a few things that need fixing in the earlier sections.

Editor Hunting: Didn't I mention the MacGuffin earlier?

Recoleta: Yes. You told me to cut the whole "listening to their inner voice" scene, which was actually the cowhand's whistle. Instead, I changed the way they escape the maze to interacting with the stone pillar.

Recoleta: But to me, that pillar is just a pillar. It doesn't represent anything. Why does it have to be important?

Editor Hunting: Exactly. It doesn't represent anything. That's the whole point.

Editor Hunting: As Hitchcock once said, "In crook stories, it is almost always the necklace, and in spy stories, it is most always the papers."

Editor Hunting: Take 1942's Casablanca, for example. The transit papers in the film are a classic MacGuffin. They drive all the characters' actions, but their actual details don't matter to the audience.

Editor Hunting: It's purely a narrative catalyst, just like this stone pillar. It doesn't define the story's central theme.

Recoleta: I always thought the term came from Rudyard Kipling's novels.

Recoleta: So this is what it means in film terminology. Interesting. Oh, I should take notes.

Editor Hunting: To sum up, the most important information should always be embedded in the most critical lines. Otherwise, readers might skim right over them.

Recoleta: Fantástico! I've already thought up a few ways to make it even better!

Hunting glances at the night sky out the window.

Time has slipped away.

Editor Hunting: Hold on, little genius, it's getting late. Let's rein in the inspiration for now.

Recoleta: But it's Friday. If I don't get your feedback now, I'll have to wait until Monday before I can talk to you again.

Recoleta: Which means I'll have two whole torturous days of staring at my unfinished ending.

She theatrically clutches her chest with one hand. Hunting sighs, torn for a moment.

After a brief pause, she speaks.

Editor Hunting: Tomorrow night, after eight, I'll have some free time. I usually take some time to myself around then, but I can entertain a guest.

Recoleta: Are you ... inviting me over?

Editor Hunting: Of course. I've got a stack of piping hot revisions just waiting for you to tuck into. It'll be an all-you-can-eat buffet!

Recoleta: So, what you're saying is ...

Editor Hunting: Honestly, your novel has something special, but getting it published won't be easy.

Editor Hunting: Even if everything goes smoothly, we need at least six months to finalize the manuscript. It might not even make next year's book fair.

Editor Hunting: But what I do know is this: I can get your novel into the world, if you can finish it on time.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Templo de la Metáfora

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Templo de la Metáfora

Bedroom - Night

It's a cold winter's night, but inside, the air feels warm and inviting.

Hunting walks in, carrying an old glass pot filled with deep red liquid.

Editor Hunting: Lemon slices, apples, oranges, cinnamon sticks ... Using Malbec for mulled wine is a bit of a waste, but it does have a satisfying richness to it.

Recoleta: Oh. That actually sounds quite sophisticated. Maybe I can use that in my writing.

Editor Hunting: Go ahead. I have to say, I do like to indulge in it from time to time. Oh, and sorry for the mess. I hope you don't mind.

Recoleta: Not at all. In fact, it looks pretty tidy to me.

This place is like a palace compared to the cluttered mass of books, notes, and clothing that fills her own cramped apartment.

Editor Hunting: Sit wherever you like—the couch, a cushion, a chair; you can even take the floor if you want.

Hunting perches on the edge of the bed, setting the glass pot down on the book-stacked nightstand.

Editor Hunting: Right, there's something I need to talk to you about.

Editor Hunting: You know why I suggested you learn screenwriting, don't you?

Recoleta: To improve my narrative structure, right? Like how Hemingway, Wolfe, and Fitzgerald all shared the same editor—Maxwell Perkins?

Editor Hunting: No, no, you're giving me far too much credit, Recoleta. I'm nowhere near that level.

Editor Hunting: At first, I didn't understand why young writers like you were so obsessed with literature.

Editor Hunting: I want you to see for yourself why cinema has conquered the '90s, while literature is slowly losing traction.

Editor Hunting: I want you to hit a wall and see with your own eyes the decline of the literary world.

Recoleta: How could that be? The world of literature may falter for a time, but it'll never fade away, Ms. Hunting. It's like the trees in winter. Yes, they'll look barren for a moment, but then the spring comes.

Recoleta: That's exactly why I write.

Recoleta: The writers I admire are explorers, rebels, defiers. They never stopped to wonder which way the tides of the times were turning.

Recoleta: That defiant spirit sustained a generation of writers, and in turn, those writers rebuilt that very spirit. Now that's a cause with real meaning behind it!

Editor Hunting: Alright. I'll admit there's merit in sticking to your guns.

Editor Hunting: But tell me this: Do you think you truly understand today's literary world, Recoleta?

Recoleta: Even the great Walt Whitman said, "Even I myself often think I know little or nothing of my real life." How could we possibly claim to understand the state of literature today?

Recoleta: To me, writing is just as exhilarating as traveling around the world or slipping into a blissful dream.

Editor Hunting: Hah, I've heard that before. Writers love saying things like that. If that's how you see it, then ...

She recalls Recoleta's reckless determination in the Templo de la Metáfora.

Something distant stirs inside her, like she's being wrapped by an old knitted sweater left unworn for years.

Editor Hunting: Never mind. It's nothing.

Noticing Recoleta's eager expression, Hunting realizes that it's time to get down to business.

Editor Hunting: Alright, let's get to work before I finish this whole bottle. What happens in the second half of the story?

Recoleta: Yes! As titillating as this conversation is, I'd like to get down to getting the ending right. Oh, and I listened to what you said. I studied some books on film and incorporated more screenplay-style dialogue!

Recoleta jumps up from the floor, handing over the freshly marked-up pages.

Editor Hunting: Oh? Let's see. Last time, the protagonists escaped the fog-filled maze using their wit. Now, they're heading toward the temple's hidden chamber.

Editor Hunting: *"The whistling stopped. The cowboy and the coachman made their way toward the light beyond the fog. But, as the fog thickened, the sounds around them faded. With every step, the world grew more and more unfamiliar."*

Editor Hunting: *"At last, they found the entrance. Inside, the temple was covered in ancient runes, its walls etched with unreadable symbols and paintings. An old man and a cowhand with his cow stood in the distance, as if waiting for them."*

Editor Hunting: *"The wind carried a whisper like an ancient poem through the fog."*

Core, Templo de la Metáfora

Hunting tilts her head, listening to the faint whisper carried on the wind like an ancient poem.

It is clear. They have left behind the warmth and comfort of her home.

Recoleta: (Excited) Ms. Hunting, we're back in the story again!

Editor Hunting: (Resigned) So we are ... At least this time I was expecting it.

Editor Hunting: What's with the parentheses? Are we directing every emotion in the dialogue now?

The "secret core" is obvious. It's perched atop the massive stone platform.

Editor Hunting: (Satisfied) The most important information should always be embedded in the most critical lines. Looks like you actually took my advice, Recoleta.

Recoleta: (Eager) Yes! We're so close to the core of the Templo de la Metáfora. I can feel it!

Editor Hunting: (Focused) Alright. How do we reach it?

Recoleta: (Mumbling) "See those two crows? When they meet strangers, they turn into ghosts."

The weary-looking crow becomes an old man. He slumps in the shadows.

The fledgling crow becomes a young cowhand, swinging his legs on the stone platform.

Just as the story describes.

Old Man: (Deliberate) Hello, travelers. Your arrival was foretold, but passing through this fog will be no easy feat.

Cowhand: (Bright) A home isn't a house. It's a memory. A cow will wander when it has lost its pasture, but it will always find its way home.

Old Man: (Overjoyed) Oh dear, it's you! The ones who set everything in motion, finally here. I've waited a full century for this moment to come.

Old Man: (Solemn) Here is the case: If you wish to touch the core of the Templo de la Metáfora, you must first solve a riddle.

Recoleta: Bring it on. I love a challenge.

Old Man: (Mysterious) Dear, I cannot speak the riddle. The cowhand knows it, but even he won't just give it to you directly. It's all part of the metaphor.

Old Man: (Smirking) Please look at him. You'll have to win him over first.

Cowhand: (Giggling) Haha. Yes, yes, yes. You have to make me happy first.

Cowhand: (Sly) No, no. Why should I listen to you, old man?

The boy claps his hands and lets out another long, drawn-out whistle.

From the shadows, a cow emerges, a deep wisdom behind its eyes.

Cowhand: (Wide-eyed) Hello, big sister! This is the riddle. Only my cow can carry you up.

Old Man: (Frustrated) No. You ... you little rascal. That's not how it's supposed to work.

Before the old man can finish, Recoleta nimbly hoists herself onto the cow's back.

And—thud—hits the ground hard.

Cowhand: (Mischievous) Hahaha!

Old Man: (Winded) Heh heh! See? It's not that easy.

Recoleta wipes the dust from her face as she falls into thought.

Editor Hunting: Alright, I can't take this anymore. Why are you putting parentheses in front of every line? I told you to take inspiration from screenplay narrative structures, not copy their formatting!

Recoleta: Fine, fine, I'll fix it. But first, we need to deal with this cow.

Editor Hunting: This cow is clearly tied to the theme of your story, Recoleta. It shouldn't be too hard for you to figure it out.

Recoleta: Let me think.

Her eyes land on a feathered quill.

Recoleta: Cowhand, can you give me a hint?

Cowhand: Of course, but I'll only answer yes or no.

Recoleta: Alright. Your cow—is it a symbol of heavy responsibility?

Cowhand: No.

Recoleta: The passage of time?

Cowhand: No.

Recoleta: Is it something more abstract?

Cowhand: Yes.

Recoleta: Is it what I'm doing right now?

Cowhand: Yes.

Recoleta locks eyes with the cowhand, a triumphant smile beaming on her face.

Recoleta: Ah. Literature doesn't offer answers. Rather, it serves to raise questions and open up unexplored realms. It's about exploration, about possibility, about capturing what can't be defined.

Recoleta: Yes, I remember it from my chat with Dr. Dores. The riddle itself is the answer, isn't it?

Cowhand: ...

Cowhand: Yes.

Old Man: You've solved the riddle. Now, let it take you where you need to go.

The cowhand's playful grin fades, and he gives a nod. The old man waves his hand, and the two of them dissolve into two crow-shaped fog clouds.

The cow carries them upward, slow and steady.

Editor Hunting: So what's the old man's purpose in this story? He doesn't actually give any new information.

Recoleta: I can't really explain it. It's just the way the story goes. We have to speak to the old man before we can talk to the cowhand.

Editor Hunting: I think this section could use some reworking. Wait. Maybe it's not so simple.

Editor Hunting: "People spend their lives asking about the future, about who they'll become, only to realize everything they are was already there during childhood." Recoleta, you buried this line far too late into the story!

Editor Hunting: This section is good, but it needs to be clearer. You have to guide the readers to the meaning.

As she finishes her sentence, the cow arrives at their destination.

Hunting reaches out, her fingers touching the radiant core before her. Light surges through her fingertips, and countless images and words emerge in her mind.

Editor Hunting: So beautiful. How did you write it?

Recoleta: *"It is the sum of countless meanings, everything life has to offer. It is sung by someone at the end of their life's journey, yet in truth, it is just a word—a word meaning 'miracle.'"*

Bedroom - Night

The light fades, and the two impostor protagonists return to the warm little room.

Editor Hunting: We're back?

Hunting flips through the manuscript again, eyes sharp as they meet Recoleta's.

In the dark light, her calloused fingers trace the collar of an old knitted sweater.

It is a long-forgotten relic from her youth, woven from an impractical love for literature.

Editor Hunting: You can come over whenever I'm free on a Saturday night.

Recoleta: You mean ... besides our usual review sessions, you'll personally help me revise my novel in your free time?

Editor Hunting: But let's be clear. This isn't going to be easy. It'll take time, and there's no guarantee it'll sell well.

Editor Hunting: But I can guarantee this—an exclusive publishing deal.

Recoleta: Oh, thank you! Thank you! What ... What an absolutely wondrous outcome from our pilgrimage to the Templo de la Metáfora!

Editor Hunting: Clearly, this is going to be a long battle.

And Hunting's instincts are rarely wrong.

Recoleta: I know, Ms. Hunting.

Recoleta: But it'll be a glorious one.

In this young writer, she glimpses the lingering embers of a bygone era.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Distant Quakes

COL-311404

Distant Quakes

Bedroom - Night

Editor Hunting: Single malt whisky, no ice, and a splash of water—the perfect spring companion. This is the life, my friend.

Recoleta: I'll stick to my usual—mate tea with mint and two sugars, please.

Hunting sets two glasses down on the table.

Editor Hunting: Hold on, are you old enough to drink? Want to try mine? It's a 15-year-old Scotch.

Recoleta: Ahem, you know what I just realized? There's no need to try everything in life.

Recoleta: Yes, I should write that into the story.

Editor Hunting: Ha. Too bitter for you, eh? Guess you're still a kid at heart.

Recoleta's faux-philosophical statement has earned her a teasing remark.

Editor Hunting: I'm joking. Even if you wanted some, I wouldn't let you have it.

Editor Hunting: You know, I don't believe any writer needs nicotine or alcohol to fuel their creativity. They're just vices they become reliant on to get through the day.

Recoleta: Oh? So you're saying you're not like them?

Editor Hunting: Of course not. Haven't you figured me out by now?

Recoleta: If I remember correctly, when we first met, you lit a cigarette.

Editor Hunting: That was an exception.

Editor Hunting: Honestly, you caught me off guard that day, little genius.

Recoleta: Why's that?

Editor Hunting: Because that era you're always talking about is already long gone.

Editor Hunting: Around the time that I was born, Latin American literature was at its peak. Every writer passionate about words could feel that strong and long-lasting earthquake.

Editor Hunting: It wasn't just the rise of a single author, either. It was a collective awakening.

Editor Hunting: Everything was urgent, irreversible, as if the soul of an entire continent had suddenly become self-aware and started speaking through literature.

Recoleta: Increíble, Ms. Hunting! What a masterful way to put it!

Editor Hunting: Just a few workplace topics. That's all.

Recoleta: But you captured exactly the way I feel about it! When I look back at the writing of that generation, it's like magma rising from the Earth's core.

Recoleta: It pushes through layers of history, violence, and memory, finally breaking the surface, carrying with it ancient silt and blood.

Recoleta: Can you imagine how breathtaking, how overwhelming, how intoxicating that is for me?

Recoleta: I missed that great earthquake, but I can still feel its distant tremors. When I first put pen to paper, the tremors aligned with my very heartbeat.

Recoleta: Surely you understand what I'm saying, right?

Editor Hunting: Of course I do, Recoleta. That's exactly why I'm pushing you so hard to write something great, why I refuse to go easy on you.

Only a strict coachman can rein in a wild horse. Hunting has come to understand this deeply.

She closes her eyes and questions herself in the dark.

Editor Hunting: Forget all the damn professional theories and publishing experience. Hunting, do you think this novel is good enough?

Editor Hunting: It's good, very good. There's a lot to like about it. But ...

Camp - Morning

As summer fades into autumn, the air turns crisp and dry. Hunting strikes a flint, effortlessly lighting a fire. The iron pot above it bubbles and steams.

The scent of simmering broth makes Recoleta's stomach grumble.

Editor Hunting: That bubbling's a little noisy. Try not to scare off my prey.

Recoleta: Wha—hey, that's not my fault.

Recoleta: When you said "camping," I thought you meant a family trip or a picnic in the park, not hauling a dozen kilos of gear over two mountains to sit in the middle of nowhere!

Recoleta: And now we even have to hunt for food?

Recoleta rubs her sore shoulders as she looks on at Hunting in the distance, stalking her target.

The hunter's gaze is sharp as a hawk's, her movements precise. She crouches low, slipping into the shadows. A single rustling leaf. A flick of an ear. The prey notices too late.

The blade strikes—clean, swift, painless.

Editor Hunting: Phew. Alright. Just needs a little prep before it goes in the pot.

Editor Hunting: Don't just stand there. Give me a hand.

Under Hunting's guidance, Recoleta handles the basic tasks—cleaning, butchering, and blanching. Finally, the meat is added to the pot.

Recoleta chews on a leaf, staring at the chunks of meat bobbing in the broth.

Recoleta: So THIS is our dinner? I thought the carrots, beetroot, and celery were supposed to be the whole meal.

Editor Hunting: What kind of life have you been living?

By the time she tastes the broth, the sun has set, and the light has faded from between the trees.

Recoleta: S-Sorry, little rabbit. I'll eat you with gratitude.

Editor Hunting: Ha! That line belongs in a dark fairy tale.

Editor Hunting: Oh, and here's another fun fact for your background notes. This little guy may be called a "Patagonian hare," but it's actually a rodent, a close cousin to sewer rats.

Recoleta: So I'm actually eating ... eating ...

Recoleta: Huh? But, actually, it's surprisingly good.

Her brain and taste buds reach a swift truce.

Editor Hunting: Relax, it's wild game from the forest. It doesn't get any cleaner than this.

Recoleta: When hunger strikes, people always find a way to dress it up in poetic language to justify accepting nature's gifts.

Editor Hunting: You're getting sharper, little genius.

Two months pass ... By now, Hunting has taught Recoleta to appreciate the beauty of camping.

Camp - Night

As the night deepens, Recoleta deftly sets up a few tripwire traps around the tent, working alongside Hunting with practiced ease.

She has picked up quite a few advanced survival skills.

Editor Hunting: It's late autumn now. Tonight will be the coldest one yet.

Recoleta: Oh, I'm fine. I've dealt with much colder nights than this.

She thinks back to the endless nights in Ushuaia—the kind of cold that never quite left her memory.

Editor Hunting: It's a little early to sleep. Want to talk about something?

Recoleta: There's plenty we could talk about besides my novel. But I know we'll end up back there anyway. It's like a maze we'll forever be circling around and around in.

Hunting raises an eyebrow. There's no arguing with that.

Editor Hunting: Alright. Actually, I have thought up a new idea for how to publish your book.

Recoleta: Oh, let's hear it.

Editor Hunting: I've been turning it over in my head for weeks. Alright, brace yourself.

Editor Hunting: What if I told you your novel would work better as a trilogy, with Templo de la Metáfora as the first volume?

Editor Hunting: It doesn't necessarily mean you have to change the ending, but it certainly makes a strong case for it.

Recoleta: A trilogy? A new ending?

Recoleta: Dios mío! I'd never considered that! My protagonists have never even taken a step outside their own story, let alone leapt headfirst into a new one.

Editor Hunting: Then give it a try. Your characters already exist vividly in their world; all they need is a way to cross the barrier into a new one. A motorcycle, a carriage, even a limping old mule would do, don't you think?

Editor Hunting: We need to think bigger, beyond the bestseller list. This is about shaking the entire literary world!

Editor Hunting: Let them embark on a new adventure, Recoleta, just like the one you told me about—your journey to the end of the world.

Editor Hunting: All you need to do is throw in a murder case, give the cowboy a reason to stumble into a mystery, and before you know it, he's a private detective.

Recoleta's breath quickens at Hunting's rapid-fire pitch.

Recoleta: Wait, Hunting, slow down. I ... I don't even have the first novel's ending figured out yet.

Editor Hunting: Oh, of course. I'm getting overexcited. Take your time, Recoleta. All great writers need time to think—to struggle through their own doubts.

Recoleta: I think I should at least finish the first novel's ending before I start worrying about the next.

Editor Hunting: That's fair. But it is the harder route.

Editor Hunting: You have to be careful. Your ending needs to be deliberate, precise. Because once it's published, there's no going back.

Editor Hunting: And I don't want you to write like you're dancing with shackles on.

Recoleta: Hmm ...

Recoleta: *sigh*

Hunting oils her knife to keep it from rusting. She goes to say something, but under the dim glow of the camping lantern, she turns to see Recoleta already fast asleep in her sleeping bag.

Editor Hunting: Hm, never mind. You young people sleep like armadillos in winter—makes me jealous.

Editor Hunting: Goodnight, little genius.

Editor's Office - Afternoon

Recoleta: Hmm. It really all comes back to the trilogy.

Recoleta: If a trilogy is in fact necessary, of course I'm willing to write two more novels. But when I actually try to structure them, I realize it's incredibly difficult.

Editor Hunting: Maybe try structuring it like The Good, the Bad, and the Ugly, with a clear climax to the action?

Recoleta: I get what you mean, but last month you told me, "The story shouldn't end after the old man and the cowhand leave." What did you mean by that?

Editor Hunting: Exactly what I said. Your protagonists need to actively bring the story to an end, but not entirely.

Recoleta: But they already took the temple's core, didn't they?

Editor Hunting: Of course, but you need a hook after that—a reason for them to choose to continue.

Editor Hunting: Picture this: they took that beautiful little artifact and started heading back. Then, one of them felt an inexplicable urge—"Hey, why don't we see what's behind there?"

Editor Hunting: "The other felt uneasy. 'I'm telling you, we should just leave!'"

Editor Hunting: "'No, we have to go see what's back there!' The cowboy shrugged off the coachman's grip and bolted forward."

Editor Hunting: "Then, a few moments later, the cowboy turned back, his eyes filled with despair."

Editor Hunting: "'What did you see?' The cowboy said nothing. So, the coachman followed him to the back of the stone platform."

Editor Hunting: —"And found a sea of skeletons."

Recoleta: Where did all these skeletons come from? I don't want to write a massacre into the story.

Editor Hunting: Hear me out. What if they realize that among all these skeletons, there are only two distinct builds? That of two adult males?

Recoleta: Wait, hold on a second.

Recoleta: I'm not sure I follow.

Their thoughts are like two frayed wires, unable to connect.

For the first time, Recoleta finds herself struggling to follow Hunting's reasoning.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Charging the Windmill

COL-311405

Charging the Windmill

Apartment Rooftop

Recoleta leans against the rusted railing of her apartment's rooftop, looking out over the blurred cityscape.

Below, sparse streetlights flicker, and a distant train whistle echoes from afar.

Recoleta: I keep revising and revising it, but I still can't find the right way to write the final sentence.

Recoleta: It's been a whole week. Will I ever be able to write a proper ending?

Recoleta: No, Recoleta. You can't just falter at the first obstacle. This is part of the process. If you want to be a published writer, you have to push through.

Recoleta: Alright. Focus on the revisions. No more overthinking. Let's start with Hunting's suggestion and see where it leads.

Recoleta: "The characters need to continue their journey." But I don't understand. The cowboy went home just to search for a place to belong.

Recoleta: I want them to get lost—to stumble forward blindly, just like we do in real life, to find meaning not in reaching their destination, but in the search itself, because that is our reality.

Recoleta: How could this happen? I was haunted by the ending of The Rise and Fall of Sanity for years. And now, here I am, haunted by an ending all over again.

Recoleta: Have I not grown at all since then? Have I tried so hard all this time only to get stuck in silent stagnation all over again? Can't I grow like so many protagonists with a character arc?

Her shadow stretches long across the rooftop tiles. Then, a cool breeze brushes from behind.

Editor's Office - Afternoon

Recoleta: You mean ... the protagonists are ghosts, trapped in an endless cycle of death and rebirth?

Editor Hunting: Push it further. Make it something more concrete, easier to grasp.

Recoleta: They've suffered through countless loops, died over and over again, and, only now, in this cycle, have they finally uncovered the truth?

Editor Hunting: Good. But that's just the foundation. We should layer in some literary elements.

Recoleta blinks as she attempts to keep up with Hunting's train of thought.

Recoleta: The two crows have stood watch for a century. They have their own purpose. They shouldn't just be a plot device.

Editor Hunting: They can be symbolic. What if they represent the enslaved souls of the protagonists from the previous cycle?

Editor Hunting: Wait, no, that idea needs refining. "Souls" are overused in fiction. We need something fresher. Recoleta, any thoughts?

She thinks hard, but nothing comes to her.

Recoleta feels her words get stuck in her throat.

Recoleta: If it's your suggestion, then I ... uh ... do I have to change it this way?

Editor Hunting: ...?

Editor Hunting: It's getting late. Let's leave it at that for today.

Hunting notices something is off. She walks Recoleta to the door, her breath fogging in the cold air.

Editor Hunting: Don't push yourself too hard, Recoleta.

Editor Hunting: Remember: first, we're writing a novel, not a screenplay. Second, there's a lot we can learn from cinema's visual storytelling. Third, we need to make sure every reader can follow the story.

Editor Hunting: Always keep those three points in mind.

Recoleta: I'll finish it, Ms. Hunting. I'll figure out the ending.

Editor Hunting: Be careful on your way back home. Stay on the well-lit streets.

Recoleta: Got it. See you next week!

A pen scratches against paper, leaving behind hurried strokes of ink.

Recoleta: So the cowboy and the coachman see their remains—evidence of the endless cycle and their endless deaths—and sink into despair. That's it, right?

Recoleta: If that's the case, what does it all mean? Shadows, home, distant echoes—none of them seems to connect.

Recoleta: Letting go of past burdens and making peace with oneself—sure, that works. But what about the old man and the cowhand?

Recoleta: "The struggles of old age and the origins of childhood." If reconciliation were that simple, why go all the way back home in the first place? It doesn't add up.

Recoleta paces back and forth on the rooftop.

Recoleta: No, no, Recoleta, you can't think like that. You've already wasted too much time talking to the moon.

Recoleta: Don't just think about it. Pick up the damn pen.

Her restless hands grip the rusted railing, making it groan under the pressure.

Recoleta: Take up your pen, Recoleta.

Recoleta: Remember that fire, that hunger to write. You have to prove you're not weak.

Recoleta: Get back to your room, sit at that cursed desk, and write that ending.

Hurried footsteps echo down the stairwell.

Another long night has begun.

Cafe

As dawn rises, the sky turns pale as the café welcomes its first customer.

Barista: I'm sorry. We're not open yet. Oh? Recoleta? Haven't seen you in a while! Did you quit?

Recoleta: Hey, Gonzalo! As you can see, I'm working on a novel.

Recoleta lifts the notebook and thick stack of papers that are tucked beneath her arm.

Recoleta: Can I have a black coffee? Two sugars, no milk. Thanks.

Barista: Of course. I'll sneak you a doughnut, too. Just don't tell the boss.

Recoleta: Thanks, Gonzalo! By the way, since the place is empty, would you like to take a look at my novel?

Barista: Oh, dear! You're gonna hit me with another one of your incomprehensible metaphors, aren't you?

Recoleta: No, no, trust me, this time it's different. I've got an editor now. She's given me some excellent advice.

Recoleta: I'm writing a trilogy, actually, and I've just finished the first novel.

Barista: Sounds great. Alright, future bestseller.

Gonzalo places the coffee and doughnut on the counter before leaning against the register and opening up the notebook.

By the time the sky has fully brightened, his fingers linger on the last page for a long while before he finally closes the manuscript.

Barista: That's awesome! So this time, it's an adventure about escaping a temple? This isn't like anything you've written before. Why the shift in style?

Recoleta: That's not important. Tell me, is it good?

Barista: That's surprising. I've never read anything like it. It's exciting and eerie, that's for sure. It's like watching a psychedelic movie or something.

Barista: Great! Finding a pile of your own corpses, realizing the core is a secret, then becoming a detective wandering the wilderness—It's really great!

Recoleta: But don't you think the cowboy and the coachman never truly get the ending they deserve?

Barista: Why?

Recoleta: They set out once more to uncover the secret of the "Ageless."

Barista: Here's the case: Nothing is wrong with a journey of discovery. I mean, Don Quixote is a knight's adventure too, isn't it? And everyone says that's a classic.

Recoleta: Don Quixote isn't just a silly man on a bony horse fighting windmills. That story really makes people stop and think. It's something they keep coming back to.

Barista: My friend, you've got your characters staring at a mountain of their own corpses! I'm pretty sure that's enough to get people thinking for a while.

Recoleta: Haha, you've got a point.

Recoleta: Thanks for humoring me and for the doughnut. Maybe I'm not as unsure as I thought.

Barista: Hmm? Unsure? The book's already finished, isn't it?

Recoleta: Yes, but I've been stuck on where to take the second novel for weeks now. My mind's so empty it's like a barren desert in there.

Barista: Haha. No way! You're Recoleta! Your ideas usually come faster than you can write them down! Ah, wait, I get it. I guess you put it all into this novel, right?

Barista: But I'm not gonna pretend I understand all that fancy "literature" talk you're always on about. But if all you worry about is whether something is "literature" or not, you might forget why you started writing in the first place.

Recoleta: Why I started writing?

Recoleta: Why did I start this story in the first place?

Gonzalo's voice fades, blending into the clinking cups and hushed conversations of the café.

Recoleta stares at the manuscript. Is the answer buried somewhere between the lines?

Recoleta: Since my last visit, how many Saturdays have I missed?

Recoleta: It's Saturday again. What time is it?

Recoleta: Forget it. It doesn't matter as long as I write something good.

She turns over, burying her face in the couch cushion.

Recoleta: Something good ...

Recoleta: What have I even written these past few weeks?

Recoleta: Look at this mess—endless, meandering descriptions, broken dialogues, characters wandering around without purpose.

Recoleta: It's a complete joke.

Recoleta: Just go ask Ms. Hunting, Recoleta. Didn't you say she was your Maxwell Perkins? She'll have some nuggets of wisdom for you.

Recoleta: Maybe tonight I can finally pin down the outline for Chapter II. I wonder if Ms. Hunting has any more concrete suggestions. Yes, maybe—just maybe—we can solve everything tonight.

Recoleta: But first, let me calm my mind before heading out.

Recoleta: Maybe I just need a little siesta.

Recoleta: *sigh*

As she drifts off, fragments of chaotic dreams claw at her mind.

By the time everything settles into silence, the room has been nearly entirely swallowed by darkness.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Laberinto de Símbolos

COL-311406

Laberinto de Símbolos

Forest North, Labyrinth

Recoleta: I ... fell asleep?

Recoleta: Wait, what time is it? I have to go see Ms. Hunting.

In the forest, the trees sway in perfect rhythm. Their movements are so eerily human that they almost feel choreographed.

Recoleta: I know this dance. It's a tango.

She has once seen this fiery dance before.

Recoleta: Whoever's behind those trees, come out! I know you're watching me!

???: At last, you have returned, Recoleta. We've waited a century to see you once more.

Recoleta: Who are you? Why are you hiding in the shadows?

Recoleta: Step forward so I can see your face. Otherwise, don't blame me if I'm a little curt.

???: There is no face to see, child. I am but a shadow—a reflection cast from the depths of your mind.

The weary, clouded voice becomes clearer.

Recoleta: A reflection of my mind? You mean I'm dreaming?

"Numb": Yes. This is your inner world—an intricate labyrinth of symbols built by your very self.

Recoleta: Labyrinth of symbols? That's a nice name, kind of like the Templo de la Metáfora—same kind of thing!

Recoleta: Thanks, stranger. I think I just found the name for Chapter II.

Recoleta: But wait. You're saying these swaying, ghostly trees are all part of a greater symbol?

"Numb": Sharp as ever. Each tree here represents a symbol you once carefully cultivated.

Recoleta: What's wrong with them? Don't tell me they're actually dancing.

"Numb": Not long ago, this labyrinth fell into disorder. Now, every tree is caught in this restless, unsteady sway.

"Numb": This is the source of your insomnia.

Recoleta: You waited here just to tell me this?

"Numb": I am here to guard over the farthest reaches of the north. This place is so cold and indifferent that it numbs all who enter.

"Numb": And you have touched the boundary I watch over. I'm too tired. I must leave.

"Numb": Goodbye, Recoleta. And heed my final advice: Do not believe a word it says.

Recoleta: Advice? Who's "it"?

Recoleta: I understand you all too well.

Recoleta: I also threw myself into the fire without a moment's hesitation.

Recoleta speaks to herself, a sadness creeping over her.

She never got the chance to say goodbye. But now, she has to move forward, or she'll be trapped in this labyrinth forever.

Forest East, Labyrinth

Recoleta: Whoever's hiding behind those rocks, come out!

Recoleta: The tortoise of the north has already told me the truth. Now tell me: What do you represent?

"Enlighten": Ah. You've finally arrived, child.

"Enlighten": For an entire century, the east has remained untouched.

"Enlighten": What is it you have faced out there?

The old voice is steady, rich with quiet power.

Recoleta: That has nothing to do with you.

"Enlighten": Oh, my dear, it has everything to do with me—with us.

"Enlighten": You write and rewrite and rewrite your rewrites, but it's never quite right, is it? You've descended into an endless cycle of revisions.

Recoleta: ...?!

"Enlighten": Remember this, child. The words you cut away never truly disappear. They become a part of you, flowing through your hand and onto the pages of your next work.

"Enlighten": Great stories are born from relentless revision. That is the fate of a writer.

Recoleta: But readers will never see the parts I erase. They only exist in my mind—torture me alone!

Recoleta: What's the point of it all?

"Enlighten": But that doesn't diminish the value of every phrase, every word, every syllable, whether or not they serve the plot.

Recoleta: Then tell me, why must they be erased?

Recoleta: Isn't it because I put too much into the individual sentences and don't consider their connection to the story?

"Enlighten": That is of no matter, child.

"Enlighten": What matters is—you are afraid you are the one who killed the cattle, are you not?

Recoleta: ...?

"Enlighten": But you simply set them free. Do you remember now?

"Enlighten": In the world you created, the cowhand has no need to herd, and the cattle have no need to graze. You provided them the freedom to chase the stars.

Recoleta: Even if my cowboy becomes a detective, even if he's doomed to walk a tragic path, is that something I have to accept?

"Enlighten": Of course. To write is to leave the traces of life in the hearts of the readers.

"Enlighten": A tale of beauty, joy, and miracles must also carry the scars of trauma and conflict,

"Enlighten": for a writer not to suffer the same scars as their readers would be unjust.

Recoleta: No, I don't believe you.

Recoleta: Do you really think that will make me feel better? I've told myself the same thing a thousand times before, and in the end, it never meant anything.

The old voice hesitates. There is a tinge of resignation behind it.

"Enlighten": Well, words have no power. Only experience can convince a person.

"Enlighten": I will leave this place, as you wish.

"Enlighten": At the very least, heed this advice.

"Enlighten": If ever you are to reach the southern forest, do not believe a single word it says.

"Enlighten": Remember that, child.

Forest West, Labyrinth

"Cheering": What's got you so worn down, Ray?

A bright, playful girl's voice flits through the dim forest light, as lighthearted as a fairy from a storybook.

Recoleta: Who ... are you?

"Cheering": Hehe! Look around you, Ray. Isn't this forest so beautiful? We spent so many dreamy summers in this little Garden of Eden.

"Cheering": But it's been so long since you've come to see me.

The girl's voice falters, tinged with unmistakable sadness.

Recoleta: We were friends?

Recoleta: Oh my! That's right! How could I have forgotten you?

A distant sense of nostalgia surges through her—a memory of a childhood companion she once knew so well.

Yes, how could she have forgotten her?

Recoleta: What ... What are you doing here?

"Cheering": Don't tell me you've forgotten, Ray. We used to sit under the trees together in summer and watch the clouds roll over the hills in the distance.

"Cheering": You wrote a poem about it, remember? "The clouds are cotton candy, and I will swallow them whole." You gave it to me.

Recoleta: I wrote something that childish? That's ... kind of cute.

"Cheering": Oh, how I've missed you, Recoleta, my best friend, my little panda cub, my green-eyed knight!

The sheer sincerity in her voice sends a tremor through Recoleta.

Recoleta: I-It's been so long! I've missed you so much!

Recoleta: Come out from behind the fireflies, my friend. Let me see you. You've grown up, haven't you? Just like I have.

"Cheering": You've been lost in your work for so long. I feel sad for you, but I can't help you.

Recoleta: ...?

"Cheering": You've forgotten so much, Ray—so many things that were pure and beautiful.

"Cheering": You had such a perceptive and sensitive soul. The poems you wrote for me were so delicate and eternal.

"Cheering": Has the world of reality weighed so heavy on you?

"Cheering": If you're tired, then let's play in the forest for a while, shall we? Just until you're ready to leave.

"Cheering": Will you stay with me, best friend?

Recoleta: Yes, I'd love to—

Recoleta: "Reality"?

The jarring sensation clears Recoleta's mind. She shakes her head, her green eyes flashing with a sudden sharpness.

She's like a child waking from a long dream, realizing their imaginary friend never truly existed.

Recoleta: Stop playing games, liar!

Recoleta: I've already met two of your companions. Tell me, what are you the symbol of?

"Cheering": Oh, no, no. I'm not a liar.

"Cheering": How could you say that, Ray?! You ... you're breaking my heart.

"Cheering": You don't even remember the first time you picked up a pen, do you?

"Cheering": All these years of waiting, only to be met by a cold-blooded executioner!!

"Cheering": If you're truly this cruel—this heartless—then I won't stay here any longer!

"Cheering": Goodbye.

Recoleta: Hmph. Goodbye then.

Recoleta shakes her head as she tries to block out the sorrowful girl's voice.

She clenches her teeth. It's just a symbol. She never had a friend like that.

Recoleta: I won't believe a word. I have to find a way out. I have to escape!

Forest South, Labyrinth

Through the pain and confusion, Recoleta stumbles forward, the crunch of fallen leaves and snapping of branches echoing beneath her steps.

But, under the siege of exhaustion, she collapses. As she lies on the damp earth, her head throbbing, she closes her eyes.

When she raises her head again, a pitch-black cave stands before her. From the depths of the darkness comes a voice—warped, deranged, neither male nor female.

"Slighted": At last, we meet. Our most magnificent writer, welcome to the southern forest.

"Slighted": My three dear friends, I hear, have spoken quite a bit of ill about me.

Recoleta: No, I won't listen to you. You ... All of you are liars!

"Slighted": This is a paradox—a chaotic Pandora's box.

"Slighted": If the others lied, then surely I am the one to tell the truth. Who is it who truly deceives you?

Recoleta: You ... You're the last one, aren't you? What exactly do you represent?

"Slighted": I am the black hole in your heart, that shadowy place where all your desires fester.

"Slighted": Anxiety is a poison. It seeps into your words, warping their taste.

Recoleta: Why do you have to speak like that? It's unbearable.

"Slighted": I can smell it—the stench of doubt laced in your hurried breath.

"Slighted": You are a proud, self-absorbed, grandiose writer.

"Slighted": Listen to yourself. Go back. Go back to where you belong.

Recoleta: Damn it. I don't have time for this. I have to go back!

Recoleta pushes herself up, the pain in her head gone, her body brimming with energy.

Then, she freezes in confusion.

"Slighted": For someone like you, growth may very well be a crime.

"Slighted": You should have been nothing but a beast of literature—untamed, unyielding.

Recoleta: I ... have to ... go back. But ... to where?

Recoleta: What ... am I going back for ... again?

"Slighted": You will never escape from that sorrowful, secretive, ceaselessly murmuring scene.

"Slighted": Literature is not merely a refuge of kindness and warmth. It is also a sanctuary for resentment and spite.

Recoleta: Why ... do I have to ... go back?

Recoleta: I ... belong ... to ... the ... fictional ... world.

Recoleta: I ... am ... fiction.

"Slighted": Our mission is complete.

"Slighted": This symbolic labyrinth is now entirely in your hands.

"Slighted": Farewell.

The labyrinth falls into an irreversible collapse.

Recoleta's eyes are vacant.

A writer must have relentless desire.

A writer must have enduring resilience.

A writer must have an innate perception.

A writer must have unshakable arrogance.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Fable of the Failure

COL-311407

Fable of the Failure

Editor's Office - Morning

Publishing House Director: Hunting, we've been talking for nearly an hour now. I need a conclusion.

Publishing House Director: So far this year, the H.A. Publishing House hasn't had a single book break into the top three bestsellers. That's an undeniable fact.

Editor Hunting: Of course, Director. I've been in close contact with several authors and have already prepared multiple commercial plans. Their new drafts will be submitted soon.

Publishing House Director: I've heard these words far too many times, Hunting. The market's changing too fast, and the readers' tastes are unpredictable. I think we need to explore new directions.

Editor Hunting: I firmly believe that literature is our way forward, Director.

Publishing House Director: Here's the case. "Literature" was indeed once our major selling point. But now, slogans like "The Vanguard of the Literary Revival!" and "The New Generation's Pedro Páramo!" have been overused.

Publishing House Director: Listen. I need to give the investors a clear conclusion before the acquisition at the end of the year.

Editor Hunting: I understand, Director.

Editor's Office - Afternoon

Recoleta: Long time no see, Ms. Hunting. How have you been?

Editor Hunting: Recoleta? Where have you been?

Editor Hunting: I asked after you at the café, but no one knew your address. They said that they've barely seen you since you quit.

Recoleta: Ah. Yes, I'm sorry for missing so many appointments. But please believe me, I had to take the time to reconstruct the symbolic forest labyrinth.

Editor Hunting: Forest? What forest?

Editor Hunting: More importantly, have you finished your outline of Chapter II? Let me remind you that this month—

Recoleta: No, there's no need for an outline! The Symbolic Forest is the name of Chapter II.

Recoleta: I've already completed it.

She pulls a thick manuscript from under her cloak. Fortunately, it is mostly untouched by the rain.

A relieved smile comes across Hunting's face.

Editor Hunting: This is probably the best news I've had all month. You're almost writing like a professional author now, Recoleta.

Editor Hunting: Alright, then let me take a look. How did our cowboy and coachman travel from the temple to a forest?

Hunting flips to the first page of the manuscript.

Silence hushes over them.

The soft scratch of a pencil, the rustle of pages, the gentle patter of rain.

A sharp snap as the pencil lead breaks. A long, deliberate inhale. A look of utter disappointment.

Editor Hunting: This is what you're submitting?

Recoleta: I ... I wrote it with all my heart.

Editor Hunting: Recoleta, do you know what this is?

Hunting stands up, gathers the manuscript neatly together, and pushes it toward Recoleta.

Editor Hunting: A scorched, lifeless forest. Desolate. Empty. There's ... there's nothing here!

Editor Hunting: You've let me down, Recoleta.

Editor Hunting: Freedom of expression does not equal reckless indulgence. You've repeated every mistake I pointed out in your last manuscript.

Editor Hunting: Your world is totally unwelcoming.

Sizzle, sizzle, sizzle—the burnt ends of electrical wires spark.

Hunting's voice grows distant as countless flashing fragments emerge.

Flashes of polite yet firmly rejecting letters.

Flashes of faces filled with prejudice and indifference.

Flashes of scenes repeated over and over again, every one wounding her heart a little more.

Recoleta: Why should I seek their approval?

Recoleta: I've never truly been accepted by those who view literature with prejudice and misunderstanding.

Editor Hunting: Enough.

Editor Hunting: That's your problem to deal with. It's not my place to get involved.

Editor Hunting: But I can't help you publish this kind of literature. It's totally self-indulgent.

Editor Hunting: Of course, you're free to ignore my advice. You are the writer, after all. I'm just an editor.

Recoleta feels dizzy, an unnamed sense of conflict taking over her.

Outside, the sky is covered in dense, impenetrable clouds, and a torrential rain is about to engulf the city.

Without a word, she grabs her manuscript, stands up, and runs out of the office.

Street

As Recoleta runs through the rain, it gradually extinguishes the flames of defiance burning within her.

As rationality returns, questions begin to claw at her.

Recoleta: Following the flow of instinct, avoiding self-examination—that's my current state of writing.

Recoleta: Ugh. Well, of course, I know this isn't exactly professional writing.

Recoleta: But ...

Recoleta wipes the rain from her forehead with her sleeve.

She leans against the wall and buries her head tightly in her arms.

Wasteland - Morning

The cool air is quickly replaced by a scorching heat, the raindrops becoming sweat, her clothes drying instantly.

She and her words return to their original state, like a blank page untouched by ink.

All the structures drawn under guidance, all the carefully added embellishments, now crumbled to dust.

Recoleta: This desert ... It looks familiar.

Recoleta: Wait, isn't this ...

Recoleta: The desert by the town of Amalfitano?!

Recoleta: No, I tore this place apart. I can't possibly be back here, back to this wasteland.

???: Who told you this place was a wasteland? To my mind, it is ten times more remarkable than anywhere else in the world!

A shadow suddenly blocks the sun. Recoleta looks up.

Recoleta: Who are you? Are you ... me?

Recoleta: No, that's not right. What are you the symbol of?

Gaucho Rider: I'm not a symbol at all. I'm the Gaucho Rider of 1975, the legendary cowgirl of Sonora —Recoleta!

Recoleta: You're Recoleta, then who am I?

Gaucho Rider: We exist in thousands of forms across endless pages. The faces we present to readers are limitless.

Gaucho Rider: You tore up The Rise and Fall of Sanity. After that, you chose to return to reality, didn't you? But I chose to stay here, in the realm of fiction.

Recoleta: What are you doing here?

Gaucho Rider: I don't have time to sit around and chat. My comrades need rescuing.

Gaucho Rider: I must rally our people—unite our strength to turn these ruins into a library! Because the library is the greatest metaphor of mankind!

Gaucho Rider: Will you stand with me and help write the next chapter of our cause?

Recoleta: You really are me. I can't think of anyone else who would speak such nonsense.

Gaucho Rider: Come on, Recoleta! Get moving!

Gaucho Rider: Cross the silent desert, follow the Gnostic River to its source, and find a way through the cave dwellers' settlements. In nine or ten nights, the Ruinas Gloriosas will appear.

Gaucho Rider: And there, an important comrade awaits our rescue.

Recoleta: Alright. But how can you prove we'll find this so-called ruin?

The Gaucho Rider pulls out a rusty badge.

Gaucho Rider: See this—? It's my badge of honor!

Gaucho Rider: There was no grand ceremony when it was awarded to me. In fact, there was no official honor from it. But still, it is an irreplaceable symbol, the undeniable proof that we will find the Ruinas Gloriosas.

Recoleta: It's beautiful! How did you get it?

Gaucho Rider: What happened to you? You really aren't anything like me anymore.

Gaucho Rider: Listen to your heart. There's something missing, isn't there?

Recoleta: ...?

Gaucho Rider: "Blessed me, blessed me, my beating heart does drum—the fervent words of visceral realism, within my chest they thump." Isn't that a poem you wrote?

Recoleta: ...?!

Gaucho Rider: Well, you may have forgotten much, but none of that matters now. A new adventure lies before us!

Gaucho Rider: Let reality be torn apart! And should we fail, let us fail spectacularly!

Recoleta: ...!

Recoleta: Come on, Recoleta! Get moving!

Recoleta takes her own hand.

What a strange feeling, like curling up under a blanket in winter.

She returns to that comfortable place.

Optimistic, reckless, an anonymous writer chasing the literary explosion era.

Recoleta: Failure doesn't diminish the glory of the journey.

Recoleta: At the very least, I'll earn a badge of honor, just like hers! Haha.

Recoleta: Yes, and my novel will be that badge!

TO BE CONTINUED...

Meaningless Acts

COL-311408

Meaningless Acts

Corridor, H.A. Publishing House

Spring has come, bringing a renewed energy with it.

Recoleta, her heartbeat thumping in her ears, steps into the publishing house building.

She carries no manuscript, only a letter—one barely large enough to contain a single long poem.

Recoleta: Alright, just drop off the letter, and it's all over.

After taking a deep breath, she slips the envelope into the manuscript submission mailbox and turns toward the exit.

Recoleta: Thank you, Ms. Hunting. And I'm sorry.

Editor Hunting: Whether to thank me or apologize, you should say it in person, Recoleta.

Recoleta's hand, reaching toward the door handle, freezes.

Following the rustle of an envelope being opened, Hunting's voice echoes from behind.

Recoleta: Ms. Hunting.

Recoleta watches as Hunting slowly approaches.

Under the overhead lights, she can barely make out Hunting's face.

Recoleta & Editor Hunting: I'm sorry.

Recoleta & Editor Hunting: ...?

Editor Hunting: The buildup to this answer is too long—long enough for the readers to nearly forget the question.

Editor Hunting: Of course, these are your characters. Your unique style shapes them, making them one of a kind.

Editor Hunting: And I—I am a business hunter who works for profit, a bookseller who has abandoned her instincts.

Editor Hunting: If I've already grasped its vitality, why should I question the purpose of each ripple?

Editor Hunting: In you, I see an old sweater I once knitted—a glorious illusion.

Editor Hunting: I used to fantasize that the distant tremors would once again shake my heart through your words.

Editor Hunting: And this unrealistic fantasy is also my selfish desire.

Editor Hunting: You should imagine yourself living purely, happily—like a true poet.

Editor Hunting: Grow wildly, cast aside the damn pursuit of fame, and live recklessly.

Editor Hunting: And write. Write and write and write.

Editor Hunting: It's been an honor to know you, Recoleta.

Editor's Office - Afternoon

A familiar setting, but the positions have shifted.

Recoleta leans back in the editor's chair, while Hunting sits upright on the other side of the desk.

Recoleta: Is this ... a metaphor for seeing things from a different perspective? Of empathy?

Editor Hunting: No, I just sat for too long, and my back hurts.

A moment of humor brings a smile to both their faces, melting the slightly icy moment between them.

Recoleta: I realize now that I never really understood you, Ms. Hunting, nor did I really try to.

Editor Hunting: Me too. I never really tried to understand what you truly thought. So, we're even.

Editor Hunting: But if you'll listen, I'll tell you a story.

Editor Hunting: A story about a young woman born during the literary explosion era.

A faint tremor flickers in Hunting's eyes.

Recoleta can sense the subtle change in her.

Editor Hunting: After graduating from the University of La Plata's literature department, the young woman declined her professor's invitation to pursue further studies and chose to enter the publishing industry instead.

Editor Hunting: In her handwritten letter, she wrote, "Professor Carlos, I want to be the Maxwell Perkins of Latin America."

Recoleta: Why would she want to be an editor when everyone else at that time was striving to be a writer?

Editor Hunting: This world has never been short on writers and poets, but these geniuses need someone to pass on their inspiration.

Recoleta: But she did become a great editor, didn't she? Because she's you.

Editor Hunting: No. She didn't become a great editor. She became a shrewd merchant.

Editor Hunting: You know, I've always worried that I would distort your work. Maybe the first version was already the best. Who could really say?

Editor Hunting: This is the eternal dilemma and ultimate question of an editor. It haunts me at night. Heh, in those moments, I feel like I'm the prey.

Editor Hunting: Don't get me wrong. I still think it's great when the books I edit are adapted into films, but I can't forget what they began as—Literature.

Editor Hunting: Literature is eternal. It's irreplaceable.

Words rush into Recoleta's mind—discussions about revisions, debates about literature, insights into life.

They wash over her like a rushing river.

Recoleta: I have an idea. A good one, I promise.

Recoleta: Even though I've given up on publishing my novel, I promise you, I will finish it.

Recoleta: Would you help me finish my novel? Not as an editor, but as a friend?

Recoleta knows this might be a meaningless act.

Editor Hunting: Of course. It's a deal!

Editor Hunting: It would be my honor, Recoleta. Let's complete this work together.

Editor Hunting: Yes, as friends, as literary companions, as people following their own desires.

Hunting knows this choice comes from an unnamed courage.

And she chooses to believe in literature, in fate, in acts that seem meaningless.

Just like Recoleta.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Ruinas Gloriosas

COL-311409

Ruinas Gloriosas

Wasteland - Night

On that pitch-black night, Recoleta sees no one.

Recoleta: Why am I back in the desert? Where did Hunting go?

Gaucho Rider: You've drunk the poisoned wine, Recoleta. A treacherous scheme of the cave dwellers.

Gaucho Rider: It's the venom of the ouroboros's fangs, severing the cause-and-effect leading us to the Ruinas Gloriosas.

In her mind, her own voice echoes.

Gaucho Rider: They tried to stop us, but fortunately, they didn't know that we are one and the same.

Gaucho Rider: I left Directrices de Metáforas in your notebook. It will lead you to the final ending.

Recoleta: You took the poison for me? But why? Why did you sacrifice yourself? Haven't you longed to see the victory of our great movement?

Gaucho Rider: No more questions. It was a necessary sacrifice.

Gaucho Rider: I did it for us. Now, go. Save our comrades and see this journey through to the very end!

Recoleta: I understand now. The comrade you're talking about is Hunting, isn't it?

Recoleta: I need to find the Ruinas Gloriosas and free her.

Recoleta snaps back to reality, pushes herself to her feet, and strides forward with determination.

Recoleta: *"Cross the silent desert, follow the Gnostic River to its source. A forgotten river runs, its course to all untold ..."*

Recoleta: *"At the source of the Gnostic River, in shrouded darkness laid, within that mirror, the cave dweller hides, his ancient face displayed."*

Recoleta: So I just need to follow this river, right?

Gnostic River Source

Recoleta: Phew, what a long night. Looks like I've finally found the source of the Gnostic River.

Recoleta: And now? There's no other path forward.

Recoleta: Wait. Could it be ...?

"Within that mirror ..." Recoleta gazes at the black surface of the water.

She pinches her nose shut and leaps in.

Recoleta feels herself sliding downward through a cave, yet there is no sense of wetness or flowing water.

Recoleta: Whoa ... Waaaah! ... Haha, waaah!

Recoleta: Wee! Hahaha! This is actually kind of fun!

Cave

She lands in a misty, damp cavern.

Recoleta: *"Tread lightly, do not disturb those shadowed tribal dwellers. Their language is as unyielding as stone, their gazes deep as caverns."*

Recoleta: The cave dwellers ... Are they those figures wandering around?

Recoleta: Can they really see me? Their eyes look completely vacant. Maybe I don't need to hide at all.

Cave Dweller I: Grant me immortality!

Cave Dweller II: Grant me glory!

Recoleta: Aah! Stay away from me!

Recoleta takes off running, ignoring everything as she sprints forward.

After passing through countless identical caves, Recoleta finally stops to listen. No footsteps, only the sound of an inexplicable underground wind.

Recoleta: Phew, finally lost them. That wasn't so bad.

Recoleta: Let's see, the next line says ...*"The ninth and tenth time darkness falls, Las Ruinas Gloriosas shall appear—to mark the journey's end, in ruined glory and radiance, clear."*

Recoleta: So, am I supposed to sleep down here for over a week to unlock the next puzzle?

Recoleta: Wait. I see! This is a puzzle too!

Recoleta: This place is still lit! So, to make "darkness fall," I need to extinguish all these braziers.

The flames instantly go out, as if responding directly to Recoleta's thoughts.

Recoleta: Alright, one more. On to the next cave.

Recoleta: Hmm, if my count is right, this should be the tenth cave.

There is no path ahead, only a thick, gray mist.

Recoleta: "To mark the journey's end"—so that mist must be it? I see. I need to complete the "ninth and tenth time" to reach the tenth night.

Recoleta: But, "ninth and tenth" ... What does that even mean? What if I extinguish the last fire in this tenth cave?

Recoleta sits cross-legged, staring at the final brazier.

After a long pause, she suddenly laughs, then picks up the brazier with both hands.

Recoleta: It must be this brazier! It marks the boundary between the ninth cave and the tenth.

Recoleta: Wow. These metaphors and symbols really are hard to understand. I think I finally get why people struggle with my novels.

With all her strength, she hurls the flames into the mist.

Recoleta: Go! Bring forth the light!

The Ruinas Gloriosas

The mist scatters. Ahead, four enormous phantoms loom.

Behind them, she barely makes out a shackled figure in the darkness.

Recoleta: Ms. Hunting?! Are you alright?

Hunting seems to be speaking, but an unseen barrier muffles her voice.

"Numb": I tried to stop you, but you still came.

"Enlighten": Child, why must you seek the secret of the "Ageless"?

"Cheering": Executioner, your cruelty has broken my heart!

"Slighted": How amusing. I never thought you'd make it here.

Countless voices echo in the ruins, mocking her powerlessness.

And four voices rise in unison, forming a harmony.

Recoleta: Step aside. I must rescue my comrade!

Recoleta faces the phantom symbols like a knight, her pen wielded like a sword.

Recoleta: Clearly, this battle isn't about strength. You are not the Minotaur guarding the labyrinth. You are mere obstacles, symbols created to hinder me.

Recoleta: Las Ruinas Gloriosas—the answer's in the name, right?

Symbolic Chorus: Clever little writer, what blocks your path is nothing but imaginary chains.

Symbolic Chorus: With the mere flick of your pen, you may sever them. It is unbelievably simple!

Recoleta lunges forward with her sword. In the darkness, the sounds of chains snapping ring out. But before long, more chains, newborn and endless, emerge from the abyss.

Recoleta: What ... What's going on?!

Recoleta slashes over and over again through the chains, but her efforts are in vain. Exhausted, she collapses to the ground.

A flickering shadow catches the corner of her eye. It's Hunting, off in the distance. What is she doing?

Hunting has abandoned words. She raises both hands above her head, outlining a rectangle.

Recoleta: A rectangle. What's that supposed to mean?

Hunting makes a motion as if embracing something, tracing the shape of the rectangle repeatedly in the air.

Recoleta: A ... pillar? Wait ... the pillar from before!

Recoleta: It's the pillar del Templo de la Metáfora!

Recoleta: ... The MacGuffin?!

Editor Hunting: "In crook stories, it is almost always the necklace ..."

Those quoted words strike Recoleta like lightning in a spring storm.

Recoleta: Yes, a necklace—a chain! Just like the Templo de la Metáfora. These chains are meaningless! I need to move past them and face the core of Ruinas Gloriosas head-on.

Countless chains bind and drag Recoleta to the ground under their weight. She covers her ears, struggling as she steps into the four symbols.

Recoleta: East, West, South, North!

Recoleta swings her sword in all four directions. With each strike, she bears the weight of a thousand chains.

The twisted laughter fades. Exhaustion and relief wash over her, and she collapses to the ground.

Her eyelids feel unbearably heavy. Hunting's voice grows distant.

The Pampas Plain

The cowboy gazes out the window at the prairie, the fresh green of spring filling her with an almost dreamlike sense of renewal.

Cowboy: My head hurts a little. Maybe I slept too long.

Cowboy: Those adventures seem hazy now.

Coachman: It's alright. You've already written our adventures into a novel.

Coachman: We escaped the Templo de la Metáfora, wandered for ages in the Symbolic Forest, and in the end, you saved me in the Ruinas Gloriosas.

The cowboy feels as if she's in a dream, but she knows the coachman is right. Those images slowly resurface in her mind.

Cowboy: Alright. And my novel? Is it finished?

Coachman: Have you forgotten? We wrote an eternal masterpiece and even won a significant literary award!

Cowboy: Where are we going?

Coachman: We're heading home.

Coachman: Back to Buenos Aires, back to the H.A. Publishing House for a grand award ceremony.

Coachman: And then, our story will come to an end.

The cowboy chuckles softly.

She waves at the tall figure before her.

As the carriage jostles forward, she throws open the door and leaps into the golden light of the sun.

Cowboy: Goodbye, Ms. Hunting!

Cowboy: Publishing novels, receiving awards ... None of that matters to me anymore.

Cowboy: There's a whole beautiful world before me! Shouldn't I live like a poet and go out and experience its wonders under the glorious radiance of Apollo? Shouldn't I run free, feeling the grass and earth between my toes?

Cowboy: After all, the story is far from over.

Behind her, the coachman—Hunting—watches, relief and longing coloring her face.

She waves at the soaring figure of freedom.

Editor Hunting: You're as careless as ever, Recoleta! You forgot that, in the story, you're supposed to call me Coachman!

Editor Hunting: But none of that matters now. Go, Recoleta!

Editor Hunting: Like an invincible warrior, like a falcon soaring free, like a fearless Gaucho Knight! Go forth and conquer the boundless Pampas Plain!

Editor Hunting: Good luck, rebellious, nameless writer who scorns fame and disregards all else!

Recoleta: Blessed me, blessed me, my beating heart does drum—the fervent words of visceral realism, within my chest they thump.

Recoleta: Come on home, spirits of the past!

Editorial Director's Office

The seasons cycle once more.

And a new winter arrives.

Hunting sits at her desk, warming her hands with a cup of coffee as she flips through a manuscript.

Editor Hunting: You need to dissect the salesman's psychology more deeply. Everything else is fine. If we're lucky, it might be published before spring.

Writer Thomas: Hmm? In the past, you'd have said, "No one cares about a retired salesman's story."

Editor Hunting: True. But things have changed. Just like Gregor Samsa in The Metamorphosis. You just need to write as well as Kafka, Tommy.

Writer Thomas: May I ask—what made you leave such a high-paying job to start your own publishing house?

Editor Hunting: That's a secret, a secret ... which has a little something to do with you.

Writer Thomas: Oh? You mean my novel moved you that much?!

A knock at the door interrupts the writer.

Publishing House Employee: I'm sorry to intrude, Director. We received a package—an anonymous novel addressed to you.

Editor Hunting: Let me take a look.

The employee unwraps the package and gently places a thin booklet on the desk.

Writer Thomas: Ah, Ruinas Gloriosas y Directrices de Metáforas by Recoleta—

Writer Thomas: That's ...?

Writer Thomas: Ms. Hunting, are you alright?

Editor Hunting: ... Phew.

Editor Hunting: She put the dedication in the preface. Looks like she still remembers my advice.

THE END